

year. Plus, I swore to myself I'd get out at the slightest downward move.

When I called Ms. Garrett again, I didn't mention my recent selling of everything, and she didn't bring it up either. We had a regular conversation, as if my behavior were completely normal.

One of the options that fit my new requirements, ironically, was Loews. Here I was about to buy back something I'd just sold, which proved my confidence in the new approach. I ordered Ms. Garrett to buy eight Loews September 65 calls—which cost me \$3,621.88, and to sell eight Loews September 70 calls—which gave me a credit of \$1,402.41. She didn't comment on the odd coincidence that the very options that drove me out of the market I'd now reacquired.

I also ordered her to buy 10 Budweiser September 55 calls at a cost of \$3,509.63, and sell 10 Budweiser September 60 calls for a credit of \$895.40. All in all, these transactions set me back \$4,733.70.

A few days after I took the new positions, I was waiting for my car to be fixed in the lobby of a repair shop and called Ms. Garrett to check on our progress. The market had taken a sharp drop that morning. This was bad news for my strategy. The in-the-money legs of both my spreads were dangerously close to falling out-of-the-money, the point at which I'd promised myself I'd sell.

"I think we should sell the Budweiser spread," I told Ms. Garrett. "Things are going in the wrong direction." "Sell the Bud?" she answered. "Are you sure? We like Bud." This was the last bit of advice I ever took from her. I didn't sell, then the Bud went blooey and so did the Loews. I'll spare you the details, but I closed out my Prudential-Bache account a week later and told Ms. Garrett to send me a check for the remains. Of the entire \$14,020.13 I'd invested from the beginning, I got back a check for \$3,296.56. A discouraging result, but I tried to concentrate on the \$265 I'd made in commodities.

Was this the end? Of course not. The next step was to find a new stockbroker. Instead of wasting time on interviews, I went directly to the local Dis-Com Securities, a do-it-yourself brokerage house with lower commissions than even Charles Schwab's.